Seminar Report: Writing a Cover Letter

- Facilitator: Miss Maame Afua Aikens
- Topic: Writing a Cover Letter

Introduction and Definition of a Cover Letter

A cover letter is a concise letter submitted alongside a curriculum vitae (CV) during a job application process. According to the facilitator, Miss Maame Afua Aikens, the primary objectives of a cover letter are:

- To introduce the applicant directly to the prospective employer.
- To communicate the applicant's genuine interest in the role.
- To articulate why the applicant is uniquely suitable for the vacancy.
- To provide the employer with a compelling incentive to read the attached CV.

Structural Components of a Cover Letter

A professionally organized cover letter must adhere to standard formal correspondence structure. The essential elements include:

- The applicant's name and contact details.
- The date of drafting.
- The employer's name and company details.
- A formal salutation.
- A clear statement indicating the position being applied for.

The body of the letter flows logically from the opening introduction through the candidate's core value proposition to a professional closing.

Core Content Strategies

A. The Opening and Motivation ("Why This Job?")

The introductory section must immediately capture the employer's attention while establishing clear intent:

- Applicants must demonstrate a genuine interest in the specific role.
- The text should mention specific aspects of the target company or position.
- It should connect the opportunity directly to the applicant's broader career aspirations.

B. Demonstrating Value ("Why Should They Choose You?")

To differentiate oneself from other candidates, an applicant must effectively sell their value:

- Highlight relevant skills, educational background, internship experiences, specific projects, and key achievements.
- The Core Formula: Miss Aikens emphasized using the Skill + Evidence + Relevance framework to substantiate claims.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

The seminar concluded with a review of frequent mistakes that weaken job applications. Applicants must avoid:

- Making the cover letter excessively long.
- Redundantly repeating the entire contents of the CV.
- Using a generic, uncustomized letter for every job application.
- Allowing spelling and grammar errors to persist.
- Focusing exclusively on personal desires rather than employer value.
- Employing informal or colloquial language.
- Failing to specify a precise job title.
- Using weak, cliché openings such as, *"I saw your vacancy and I am..."*.

Conclusion

The career seminar provided comprehensive insights into crafting impactful cover letters. By moving away from generic templates and adopting structured, evidence-based storytelling; highlighting specific skills, company alignment, and tailored achievements.Job seekers can significantly improve their chances of engaging employers and securing interviews.